

The Ottoman Empire

Named after its founder, a warrior named Osman Ghazi, the Ottoman Empire began as a small state in Anatolia (in modern-day Turkey) in around 1300. From the 14th to the 16th centuries, it was one of the most powerful kingdoms in the world, extending into the Arabian Peninsula, North Africa, and across large parts of Europe. It was known for its military might and advancements in science and arts. The Ottoman Empire lasted until the early 20th century.

GREAT SULTANS

1362–1389

Murad I expands the Ottoman Empire by capturing most of the Balkans, a region in southeastern Europe. He moves the empire's capital city to Adrianople, which he renames Edirne. In 1389, he is killed by a Serbian knight after the Battle of Kosovo.

1451–1481

Under Sultan Mehmed II, better known as Mehmed the Conqueror, the Ottoman army captures Constantinople in 1453, ending the Byzantine Empire. Constantinople is now known as Islambol (later Istanbul), and becomes the Ottoman capital.

1512–1520

Selim I, also known as Selim the Grim, forces his father to give up the throne, and kills his brothers to become sultan. He then defeats the Safavid Empire in Persia and the Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt. The Ottoman Empire becomes the most powerful empire in the Islamic world.

1520–1566

The empire reaches its fullest extent under Suleiman I, also called "the Magnificent." He promotes science, literature, art, music, and architecture, and brings the whole of his empire under a single system of law.

SULEIMAN I



JANISSARY GUARDS ►

The Janissary were elite soldiers who came out of the Devshirme system set up by Sultan Murad I. In this system, young Christian boys from conquered territories were converted to Islam and then trained as soldiers. Janissaries were loyal only to the sultan and formed his protective guard. They also protected frontier towns from outside attacks.

